A No Play

By Sarah Provost

INTRODUCTION

AVERY: (angrily) No.
ANNIE: (sadly) No.
AVERY: (defiantly) No.
ANNIE: (hysterically) No!
AVERY: (questioningly) No?
ANNIE: (hopefully) No?
BOTH: (with a smile) No.
AVERY: "No Play"
ANNIE: By Sarah Provost

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(ANNIE is discovered at the stove. She sets the table for two with wine glasses and candles and stirs a pot of tomato sauce, singing "Yes, We Have No Bananas." AVERY drags himself through the door carrying a briefcase, which he sets in the middle of the table. He goes to a counter, his back to ANNIE, picks up a pile of junk mail and sorts through it.)

ANNIE: Hi, honey! How you doing? Wasn't it a beautiful day? I do hate to see summer end, but the fall sky is just so blue! And the first cool weather makes me feel like cooking. So guess what we're having tonight? La-a-a-sagna! *(AVERY continues to sort through the mail without looking up.)* Avery? Didn't you hear me? *(He looks up briefly, a bit quizzical, then shakes his head.)*

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: We're having lasagna! I hope you're hungry.

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Not hungry for lasagna? Whoa! Are you OK?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Oh, poor baby! I'm sorry. What's the matter, is your stomach upset? Do you want some Turns or something?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Headache?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Well, what is it then? *(He shrugs and exits to the bedroom, taking off his tie.)* Honey? Do you want to lie down for a while?

AVERY: *(Off)* No.

ANNIE: Then come keep me company while I finish this up. I'll put it in the fridge and we can nuke it up tomorrow. You'll feel better then, huh? *(He returns minus jacket and tie, wearing a similar happi-coat.)*

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Oh, I get it. We're just in a lousy mood tonight. Obviously, this man needs a hug! *(He accepts her embrace briefly, then fends her off)* What'sa matter, baby, is Walt on your back about that report? Did Adam win the football pool again?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Then what is it, for God's sake! Aren't you going to tell me what's bothering you? *(AVERY considers for a moment, then speaks decisively as he pours himself a hefty scotch on the rocks.)*

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Why not? Huh? Avery? If you're not sick, and it's not a problem at work... Oh. Oh, I know. This is about the gerbil, isn't it? Some busybody

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happened to be passing by and couldn't wait to tell you about it, huh? Well, you could at least do me the courtesy of hearing my side of it before you get all judgmental! *(He looks up at her, mystified.)* Here's what happened. See, when I went to the mall for my Jazzercize class, this skirt is getting so tight, and I went by the pet store - I know it's out of the way, but I always have to check for kittens in the window. Don't give me that look, I'm not going to bring any home, not after the fit you threw last time. But oh, there was one in the window, a little baby gray with long hair, absolutely gorgeous, but he was asleep, so flat out, he looked like a rug. I just thought it was cute, y'know, and went on to my class. But when I walked past again and it was an hour later and he hadn't moved, well, I thought he might be ... y'know ...So I went in and asked the guy in the store - skinny kid with long greasy hair - to check on the kitten, and he looked at me like I was nuts and said, "He's sleeping, lady." And I could tell that he was just waiting for me to leave. He wasn't going to do anything! And with all that long hair, I couldn't even tell if he was breathing. The cat. So I told the guy I wanted to buy the cat and could I see him. Well, he opened the pen and picked the kitty up, none too carefully, and gave him to me. That cat could make Rip Van Winkle look insomniac! He just draped himself over my arm and went on sleeping, but I put my face right up next to his little pink nose and I could feel that he was breathing, so I gave him back. He was OK. The guy was snippy 'cause I fibbed about buying it, but I felt better that I'd checked. Now see, I don't usually actually go *in* the pet store 'cause once I'm in there I always have to see the puppies too and all the other little critters, I

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can't even not look at the lizards and tarantulas and all the ugly stuff. So I was way in the back of the store where the gerbils and hamsters and guinea pigs and bunnies are - they had the cutest little miniature lop-eared bunny, I'd've brought it home in a minute if... *(AVERY shoots her a dark look.)* Well, anyway, I was back there in the Rodent Round-up when I saw this little black gerbil peeking out from under the cover on top of his cage! Actually I couldn't tell it was a gerbil at first 'cause all I could see were his little quivery whiskers. But sure enough he was on top of his cage and not in it! At first I just told him he was a mighty clever little rascal, but then I began to get worried. What would happen to him? Maybe he couldn't get back in his cage to eat, or somebody might step on him, or lord, he could even wander into the kitten's cage by mistake. Though I don't suppose that snoozy little guy'd be much of a threat. So anyway, I called the kid and he got all snotty, grabbed the poor little thing and just threw him back in his cage! *Threw* him! I tried to talk sensibly to him about how he shouldn't be working in a pet store if that's the way he felt about animals, but he just got really snotty and, Avery, he as much as accused me of letting the little guy out in the first place! So I ... well, I *did* open the cage and let the gerbils out. And the hamsters and the guinea pigs and the little bunny too. And they were all hopping around, you know, so happy! So while he was trying to catch them I let the birds out and they flew out into the mall, some them, and as I was leaving I let the puppies out and they started to chase the gerbils and mice and stuff, but I knew they'd never catch them. I even opened the kitten's pen, but he was still asleep. Now I know you probably think I over-reacted, but if

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you had got a taste of that guy's attitude you would have done just the same thing, wouldn't you? Hm?

AVERY: *(After a beat; bemused)* No.

ANNIE: That *is* what you're upset about, isn't it?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: You didn't know about it?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Oh. Well if it wasn't that, then what is it? God, I hate it when you get mad at me and won't tell me what I've done! It's not fair! Is it because I've put on a few pounds?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Because I *am* going back to Jazzercise ... Oh! If this is about the dent in the car, that wasn't my fault! Is that what's making you so crabby?

AVERY: *(He hadn't known about that either.)* No. *(ANNIE begins to get weepy and mushy, goes to him and clings to his arm as he tries to read the paper.)*

ANNIE: Avery, honey, don't do this to me! I love you so much, and it makes me crazy when you won't talk to me. Tell me what's bothering you. I'll fix it! What am I doing that's wrong? Avery? I'm not going to go away until you tell me what's upsetting you, and don't say it's *me* because you were in a crappy mood the moment you walked in here tonight, and I'm not going to take it!

AVERY: No? *(Insulted and angry at his snotty tone, she begins to sniffle.)*

ANNIE: You can't treat me like this! This is not the person I want to be. Listen to me! You've got me all whiney and clingy and miserable, and that's not the way I am at all. I'm a very happy person, Avery, very happy, or I was until

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I got mixed up with you! I'm an optimist, Avery, one of those people who always sees the glass as half full and the skies are partly sunny. You know that. You said it's what you loved about me, remember? How I could just chatter along -like a little bird, you said and talk you out of a bad mood, cheer you right up. Now you look at me like that guy in the store did. And you know what, Avery? I'm beginning to feel like that damn gerbil! Maybe it's time I stuck my nose out of the cage. Because that's what it feels like these days, Avery, like a gerbil cage! *(She begins to sob.)* And I keep running on my little wheel, trying to make you happy, but Avery, you are not a happy person! I am a happy person! I'm hopeful and cheerful and I always believe that things will work out for the best, and I never give up hope on anything except... I am now. I'm leaving Avery. *(She starts out of the room, all injured dignity.)*

AVERY: *No!*

ANNIE: No?

AVERY: No. *(He goes to her, takes her arm, leads her back to sit at the table. He offers her his hanky and waits while she wipes her eyes and blows her nose. There is a long pause, then:)* You really don't understand me at all, do you?

ANNIE: *(Sniffling and sullen)* No.

AVERY: No matter how many times we go through this, you never learn. It isn't always about you. Sometimes I'm just in a bad mood, OK? I've got a right to be in a bad mood now and then, don't I?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: Well, maybe I carry it a little far sometimes, but Christ! You drive me

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crazy! You just push at me and push at me until I want to - Rargh! But that doesn't mean I don't care about you. Can't you understand that?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: What the hell is it with women? What do you want from me? You want me to kiss your toes three times a day? Moon around writing love poems? You want diamonds and fur coats and roses, is that it?

ANNIE: No!

AVERY: I'm sorry if I'm not all lovey-dovey every minute of the day. But sometimes I just get this kind of ... do you know what existential dread is?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: Have you ever read Heidegger?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: Sartre?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: Schopenhauer?

ANNIE: *(That name sounds familiar at first, but ...) Vh ...* No.

AVERY: Well, you ought to. I mean, he talks about how reality is just made up of this blind impelling force, and everyone has this force, and we call it will, OK? But our wills are all contradictory, so we're destined to be miserable. You see?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: Like right now. I want to be left alone and you want to harass me. So we're both miserable. But it's more than that, even. It's not just other people, you got fate to contend with too. I mean, don't you sometimes get the

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feeling there's a big cloud over your head and everyone can see it but you, and some day when you least expect it a fist is going to come out of that cloud and bash you one?

ANNIE: No!

AVERY: Open your eyes! You're an optimist, huh? An optimist is just someone who refuses to see what's in front of her. *(ANNIE, miffed, starts layering the lasagna into a casserole dish.)* How can you go around prattling about gerbils when the world is full of despair? When we have bombs and diseases and banks going belly-up and we can't even hide under our electric blankets anymore or the radiation'll get us! The sky is falling, for Christ's sake, right through the hole in the ozone! Everybody in the Middle East is ready to nuke everybody else and Africa's going to blow up any minute. To say nothing of Central America! You think it's all Tupperware and Twinkies out there? Every time you turn around there's some maniac holed up in a HoJo with an Vzi. I mean, God, how can you go to work every day and read the paper every night and still keep so damn sunny-side up? *(She turns away, puts the lasagna in the refrigerator and continues to stand with her back to him.)* Oh, don't get all teary-eyed on me again. I'm not attacking you personally. I'm just trying to explain why sometimes I don't feel like being Mr. Happy. For all we know, the whole thing could slide into oblivion tomorrow, and I'll end up on the sidewalk selling pencils and drinking Mad Dog. For God's sake, Annie, doesn't the thought of nuclear winter mean anything to you?

ANNIE: *(Defiantly)* No!

AVERY: What about Social Security going bankrupt and medical insurance getting

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sky high and neither one of us getting any younger? You have to wear reading glasses and I have to get my gums flapped and osteoporosis and prostate trouble are waiting in the wings. Doesn't that worry you?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: Haven't you noticed there's less snow every year? Doesn't global warming bother you at all?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: The depletion of the rain forest?

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: Recombinant DNA? Alluvial flood plains? *What about Tibet? (He's worked himself into a towering rage. A beat, then, in his face:)*

ANNIE: No.

AVERY: Dammit, woman, don't you ever think about anything outside yourself?

ANNIE: No! *(A beat)* Wait a minute. That's not true. I pulled off the road today to look at that gorgeous sunset. Did you?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: Did you notice the autumn crocuses blossoming under the shrubs?

AVERY: No.

ANNIE: How about the trees on the way home? All russet and amber and

AVERY: No! Dammit, Annie, do you really think that sunsets and rainbows and fuzzy gray kittens can make it all up to the homeless?

ANNIE: No. But do you think grumping around the house will alleviate the crisis in Algeria?

AVERY: No... Wait a minute. There isn't any "crisis in Algeria!"

ANNIE: No? Well, what about the crisis here? And what about me? Does making

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me unhappy make anything else any better?

AVERY: No! I don't want to make you unhappy. But can't you just ignore me and be happy on your own?

ANNIE: No. Because no matter how happy I am, it makes me unhappy to see you all unhappy. Because I love you. And so I want to make you happy but you just want me to get out of your face. I guess that isn't the way to make you happy, huh?

AVERY: *(Softly)* No. You weren't really going to leave me, were you?

ANNIE: No. Not unless you want me to.

AVERY: No. I love you too, Annie. Can't you just put up with me?

ANNIE: Maybe. But God, Avery, couldn't you make more of an effort?

AVERY: Maybe. *(He goes to her, kisses her.)* We could nuke that lasagna a little later, couldn't we?

ANNIE: Yes. *(They kiss again. And again. AVERY starts to move them toward the bedroom.)*

AVERY: Yes?

ANNIE: Yes.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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